The Vedas are the oldest scriptures of the Hindu tradition and consist of four books—Rig, Sama, Yajur and Atharva. They consist mostly of prayers, hymns and instructions on how to conduct rituals and fire sacrifices. They were composed and compiled over several centuries by poet-philosophers (or rishis). The Rig Veda is the oldest of the four and organized in ten sections. It is the oldest extant book in the world and remains in active use. Indeed, it is considered by most Hindus to be the most sacred of texts and one of its hymns, the Gayatri Mantra, is chanted daily by millions. It has been variously translated by scholars over the centuries. Here is my interpretation: 'As you light up the Heavens and the Earth, O Radiant Sun, So light up my Mind'.

The Rig Veda is composed in a very archaic form of Sanskrit and is undoubtedly very old. However, there is a great deal of disagreement about exactly how old. The dates range from 4000 BC to 1000 BC. [12] Dating it is no easy task since it was probably compiled over decades or even centuries and remained a purely orally transmitted tradition till the third century AD. Nonetheless, it is clear that the Rig Veda belongs to the Bronze Age as it does not mention iron. [13] The earliest possible mention of iron comes in the Atharva Veda which was compiled many centuries later and talks of a 'krishna ayas' or dark bronze. Since we know that iron was in use in India by 1700 BC, [14] this would roughly date the Atharva Veda. Allowing for a few centuries between the composition of the first and last Veda, it would not be unreasonable to say the Rig Veda was compiled no later than 2000 BC.

Since the nineteenth century, the Rig Veda has been used to reconstruct early Indian history. At the outset, let me point out that this is fraught with difficulty. The book is mainly concerned with religion and philosophy, and is not meant as an encyclopaedia of social and political conditions. It is a bit like guessing the history of the Roman Empire by reading the New Testament. Nonetheless, it does provide an interesting glimpse of a Bronze Age society, its social customs, its material and philosophical concerns, its